

GRADUATE VISA



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UK Graduate Visa: Eligibility, Conditions & Application Process

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The Graduate Visa is a post-study work route that enables international students who have successfully completed an eligible UK degree to remain in the UK for a period of up to two years – extended to three years for doctoral graduates – in order to work or seek employment at any skill level.

While the Graduate Visa does not provide a direct pathway to settlement (Indefinite Leave to Remain), it offers a valuable opportunity to gain work experience in the UK and, where appropriate, individuals on the Graduate Immigration Route can switch into an immigration route that leads to settlement, such as the [Skilled Worker](#), [Global Talent](#), or [Innovator Founder](#) route.

1. Graduate Visa Requirements for International Students

In order to qualify for a Graduate Visa, you will need to satisfy UK Visas & Immigration that:

- You have successfully completed a UK degree, or other eligible course;
- Your studies were undertaken at a UK Higher Education Provider that holds student sponsor status and has a proven track record of compliance;
- You have held permission as a Student, which was granted to study the relevant qualification in the UK, and you met the minimum study period requirements;
- You are applying from within the UK and have valid leave as a Student at the date of application;

- You have not previously been granted permission on the Doctorate Extension Scheme (DES), or the Graduate route;
- You do not fall for refusal on suitability grounds under the immigration rules.

The exact requirements you will need to satisfy may vary depending on your circumstances. It is advisable to seek expert legal advice to ensure that you meet all the criteria before applying.

To discuss your UK Graduate Visa application with one of our immigration barristers, contact our UK Graduate Visa lawyers on 0203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.

2. UK Degree Completion Requirements for a Graduate Visa

In order to extend your stay on the Graduate Immigration Route, you must have successfully completed a UK degree or another eligible qualification at the appropriate level. Eligible qualifications include:

- A UK bachelor's degree;
- A UK postgraduate degree (such as a master's or doctorate); or
- A professional qualification or diploma requiring study at UK bachelor's degree level or above, in a profession with reserved activities that is regulated by UK law or by a UK public authority.

In each case, the qualification must have been conferred by a UK Higher Education Provider with a track record of compliance and must be formally awarded before the date of your Graduate Visa application.

You will also be eligible to apply for a Graduate Visa if, following the completion of an eligible qualification during your most recent grant of permission as a Student, you were sponsored to undertake a role as a Student Union Sabbatical Officer.

The Graduate Immigration Route is available not only to holders of traditional academic degrees, but also to certain graduates in regulated professions and individuals who have undertaken roles in student governance, provided that all relevant academic and sponsorship requirements have been met.

3. Study at a Compliant UK Higher Education Provider

In order to qualify for a UK Graduate Visa, your qualification must have been obtained from a UK Higher Education Provider that holds a student sponsor licence and is recognised by the Home Office as having a track record of compliance. This means that your university or college must be listed on the [official register of student sponsors](#) and must not be under any form of suspension or restriction at the time of your application.

Only institutions that meet these criteria are authorised to report the successful completion of your course to UK Visas & Immigration (UKVI), which is a mandatory requirement for the Graduate Immigration Route.

4. Graduate Visa Student Permission Period Requirements

In order to meet the eligibility requirements for a UK Graduate Visa, you must have held permission as a [Student](#), which was granted to study the relevant qualification in the UK, for a minimum period of time. In most cases, you will be expected to have undertaken a substantial portion of your studies physically in the UK.

The minimum period of time for which you must have held Student permission in the UK depends on the length of the course:

- **For courses lasting 12 months or more:** You must have been granted permission for at least 12 months on the Student route and have spent that time studying in the UK.
- **For courses lasting less than 12 months:** You must have studied the full course in the UK on a Student visa.

5. Applying from Within the UK with Valid Student Visa

The Graduate route is only open to applicants who are physically present in the UK at the time of application. You must hold valid leave as a Student at the point you submit your application for a Graduate Visa.

You cannot apply from outside the UK. Applications made after your Student permission has expired will be refused, and [overstaying](#) may affect your immigration record.

6. Restrictions on Previous Graduate or Doctorate Scheme Visas

Applicants for the Graduate Immigration Route who have previously been granted leave under the Doctorate Extension Scheme (DES) or the Graduate route are not eligible to apply again under this route. The Graduate Visa is intended to provide a one-time opportunity for recent graduates to remain in the UK to work or seek employment for a limited period.

If you have previously benefited from either of these post-study work routes, you must consider alternative immigration options to remain in the UK lawfully.

7. Graduate Visa Suitability Criteria under Immigration Rules

In addition to meeting the eligibility criteria, your Graduate Visa application must not fall for refusal under the suitability requirements set out in the [Immigration Rules](#). These requirements cover issues such as:

- Criminality or serious misconduct;
- Breaches of immigration law, including deception or overstaying (unless subject to an exception);
- Non-payment of NHS debt or outstanding litigation costs to the Home Office.

Your application will be carefully assessed for any such factors. A refusal on suitability grounds may carry serious consequences, including restrictions on future applications.

8. Is Sponsorship Needed for the Graduate Visa?

The Graduate Visa Route is an unsponsored work route, meaning that applicants do not need a job offer or a [Certificate of Sponsorship \(CoS\)](#) in order to be eligible.

9. How to Apply for a UK Graduate Visa

If you have completed an eligible course and wish to remain in the UK under the Graduate Immigration Route, it is important to understand the application process and prepare your application carefully.

Graduate Visa Application Timing and Deadlines

You must submit your Graduate Visa application before your existing Student permission expires. You can only apply once you have successfully completed your course and your education provider has notified the Home Office of your



course completion. It is therefore important to confirm with your university or college when they have made the necessary notification.

Graduate Visa Application Process

Applications for a Graduate Visa must be made online from within the UK. You will need to complete an online application form, provide your Confirmation of Acceptance for Studies (CAS) reference number from your student visa application and upload supporting documents. In many cases, applicants will be able to verify their identity using the 'UK Immigration: ID Check' mobile app. Where this is not possible, you may be required to attend a biometric appointment at a UK Visa and Citizenship Application Services (UKVCAS) centre.

Graduate Visa Processing Timeframes

The Home Office currently aims to process Graduate Visa applications within 8 weeks of the application date. While most applications are decided sooner, it is advisable to apply as early as possible and avoid making non-essential travel plans until a decision has been received.

10. Graduate Visa Fees and Immigration Health Surcharge

If you are planning to apply for a Graduate Visa, it is important to be aware of the associated costs and to ensure that you are able to meet the financial requirements at the time of application.

Applicants for a Graduate Visa must pay an application fee to the Home Office. As of July 2025, the application fee for a Graduate Visa is £880. This fee must be paid online when submitting the application.

In addition to the application fee, Graduate Visa applicants are also required to pay the **Immigration Health Surcharge** (IHS). The IHS grants access to the UK's National Health Service (NHS) on broadly the same terms as a UK resident. The Immigration Health Surcharge for Graduate Visa applicants is currently £1,035 for each year of leave granted. This means that applicants who are granted two years of leave following completion of a bachelor's or master's degree will be required to pay £2,070 in Immigration Health Surcharge fees, while applicants who are granted three years of leave following completion of a doctoral qualification will be required to pay £3,105.

Both the application fee and the Immigration Health Surcharge must be paid in full at the point of application.

It is important to note that the application fee and the Immigration Health Surcharge are subject to change. Applicants are advised to check the latest Home Office guidance or seek professional advice before submitting an application to confirm the current fee levels.

11. Length of Stay on the Graduate Immigration Route

Successful applicants on the Graduate Visa Route who have completed a bachelor's or master's degree are able to stay in the UK for two years. Doctoral students are able to stay in the UK for three years.

12. Can I Extend a UK Graduate Visa?

It is not possible to extend permission to stay on the Graduate Immigration Route.

13. Switching to a Work Visa After Graduate Visa Expiry

If you wish to remain in the UK beyond the expiry of your Graduate Visa, you will need to switch into another immigration route before your Graduate permission expires.

There are several immigration routes available to Graduate Visa holders who meet the relevant requirements. The most common route is the [Skilled Worker visa](#), which enables individuals to work in an eligible role for a Home Office licensed sponsor. To qualify as a Skilled Worker, you will generally need to have a confirmed job offer from a licensed employer, meet the skill and salary thresholds of the route, and demonstrate English language proficiency, although you may benefit from lower salary thresholds if you are classified as a "new entrant" to the labour market.

Another option for some graduates is the [Global Talent visa](#), which is designed for individuals who have shown exceptional promise or exceptional talent in fields such as academia, research, arts and culture, or digital technology. Graduates who have been awarded certain prestigious prizes or who have completed PhD studies in relevant fields may be eligible to apply directly or with endorsement.

Entrepreneurial graduates may wish to consider the [Innovator Founder visa](#), designed for individuals with an innovative, viable and scalable business idea. Applicants must have their business idea endorsed by an approved endorsing body and must satisfy various requirements, including demonstrating that they will play an active role in the day-to-day management of the business.

There are also other work and business immigration routes that may be available depending on your circumstances, such as the [Scale-up visa](#), the [High Potential Individual visa](#) for certain recent graduates from eligible international universities, or [family-related immigration routes](#), where applicable.

It is important to note that each immigration route has its own specific requirements, application procedures, and evidential standards. If you are considering switching into another route, it is advisable to begin planning well in advance of your Graduate Visa expiry date to allow sufficient time for preparing and submitting a strong application.

Our immigration barristers are experts in advising graduates on their immigration options and assisting with switches into work-based routes that lead to settlement. We can help you identify the most suitable immigration pathway based on your career goals and personal circumstances, and guide you through each stage of the application process.

14. Does the Graduate Visa Lead to Settlement in the UK?

The Graduate Visa does not provide a direct route to settlement (also known as Indefinite Leave to Remain or ILR) in the UK.

However, the Graduate route is designed to provide a valuable opportunity for international graduates to gain work experience in the UK following the successful completion of their studies and, during this period, Graduate Visa holders may switch into another immigration route that does lead to settlement, provided the requirements of the route are satisfied. Your time spent on the Graduate route may also count towards time spent on the 10-year settlement route, as explained further below.

UK ILR Options After Graduate Visa Expiry

Work-based immigration categories that offer a pathway to ILR include:

- The [Skilled Worker](#) route;
- The [Self-Sponsored Skilled Worker](#) route;
- The [Global Talent](#) route;
- The [Innovator Founder](#) route.

Each of these routes has its own eligibility criteria and application process. If your long-term intention is to settle in the UK, it is important to plan ahead and seek

legal advice to ensure a smooth transition from the Graduate route into a settlement-qualifying category.

15. UK Graduate Visa Conditions and Work Restrictions

If you are granted a Graduate Visa, you will be subject to certain **conditions** during your stay in the UK. Understanding these conditions is important in order to ensure that you remain compliant with your immigration status.

Graduate Visa holders are permitted to work in the UK without restriction on the type of employment they undertake. They may work at any skill level and are not required to satisfy any minimum salary threshold. Graduate Visa holders may work full-time or part-time, be employed or self-employed, and are also free to undertake voluntary work. It is possible to switch jobs without needing to notify the Home Office, and to pursue multiple jobs at the same time.

However, there are certain types of work that are prohibited. Graduate Visa holders are not permitted to work as a professional sportsperson or sports coach. If you intend to undertake work in these fields, you would need to apply under a different immigration route that permits such activity.

In addition to the freedom to work, Graduate Visa holders may also choose to undertake further study whilst on the Graduate Immigration Route. However, study is permitted only where the course of study does not meet the requirements for Student sponsorship. If you wish to undertake a course that would ordinarily require sponsorship under the Student route, you will need to apply for a Student visa instead. This is because the Graduate visa route is primarily for those who are seeking to stay in the UK for work or job searching after completion of their studies.

Graduate Visa holders are not permitted to access public funds. This means that you cannot claim benefits or other forms of financial assistance from the UK government during your stay under this route.

It is also important to be aware that the Graduate Visa is granted for a fixed period of two years following completion of a bachelor's or master's degree, or three years following completion of a doctoral qualification. It is not possible to extend a Graduate Visa beyond this period, and holders should plan ahead if they wish to remain in the UK by switching into another immigration route.

- **What Can I Do (And Not Do) With a Graduate Visa?**

16. Impact of Graduate Visa on Long-Term UK Immigration Plans

While the Graduate Visa offers international students the opportunity to remain in the UK to work or look for work after completing their studies, it is important to understand how time spent on the Graduate route affects future immigration options.

Time spent in the UK on a Graduate Visa does not count towards the qualifying period for indefinite leave to remain (ILR). If you wish to apply for settlement in the UK, you will first need to switch into a different immigration route that leads to settlement, such as the Skilled Worker route, the Global Talent route or the Innovator Founder route. Once you have switched into a settlement route, your qualifying period for ILR will start to accrue from the date you are granted permission under the new route.

Although the Graduate Visa does not contribute towards the five-year continuous residence requirement for settlement under work-based routes, it will not prevent you from pursuing settlement at a later stage. Time spent on the Graduate route is considered lawful residence, and holders who comply with their visa conditions will not be disadvantaged when applying to switch into a settlement route.

If you eventually wish to apply for indefinite leave to remain based on **long residence**, it is also worth noting that periods spent on the Graduate route can form part of the 10 years of continuous lawful residence required for long residence applications.

It is important for Graduate Visa holders to plan their immigration journey carefully and to be aware of the time limits associated with the Graduate route. Applications to switch into another immigration route must be submitted before a Graduate Visa expires. Switching early can also help to maximise the time spent on a route that leads to settlement.

17. Can Dependants Join You on a Graduate Visa?

If you have family members in the UK who already have permission to stay in the UK as your dependent then they will be able to extend their stay when you apply to enter the Graduate Visa Route.

New dependents are not permitted on this route, except where a dependent child is born in the UK during a period of Student or Graduate leave.

18. Graduate Visa Refusals: Common Mistakes to Avoid

Although the Graduate Visa is designed to offer a relatively straightforward route for international graduates to remain in the UK, applications can still be refused if the eligibility requirements are not fully satisfied or if procedural mistakes are made. Understanding the common reasons for refusal can help you to prepare a stronger application and avoid unnecessary disappointment.

One of the most frequent reasons for refusal is failure to apply while holding valid Student permission. Applications must be made from within the UK before current permission expires. If you apply after your leave has expired, or from outside the UK, your application will be refused automatically.

Another common issue arises when the education provider has not yet confirmed successful course completion to the Home Office. You must ensure that your university or college has formally notified the Home Office before you submit your application. Submitting an application too early, before this notification has been made, may lead to refusal.

Applications can also be refused where the applicant has not completed a qualifying course. Only certain qualifications awarded by eligible higher education providers meet the requirements of the Graduate route. If you are unsure whether your course qualifies, it is important to seek advice before applying.

Suitability grounds can also lead to refusal. These include issues such as previous breaches of UK immigration laws, criminal convictions, or providing false information to the Home Office. Applicants must ensure that they answer all application questions truthfully and disclose any relevant information where required.

Incomplete or incorrect documentation may also cause a Graduate Immigration Route application to be refused. It is important to provide all required evidence, including proof of identity and immigration status, and to ensure that all documents meet the specified standards.

To minimise the risk of refusal, Graduate Visa applicants should take care to prepare their application thoroughly, ensure that all eligibility requirements are met, and submit the application at the correct time. Seeking professional advice can help to identify and address any potential issues before an application is submitted.

19. Future Changes to the UK Graduate Immigration Route



The Graduate Immigration Route was introduced in July 2021 to enable international students who have successfully completed an eligible course of study in the UK to remain and work, or look for work, without the need for sponsorship. Since its introduction, the route has proven popular with graduates and employers alike, providing an accessible post-study work option for talented individuals wishing to build their careers in the UK.

However, immigration policy is subject to change, and the Graduate Visa route has been the subject of periodic government reviews. In particular, there have been discussions around how the Graduate route contributes to the UK economy, labour market and higher education sector.

On 24 June 2025, the UK government published [Statement of Changes to the Immigration Rules: HC 836](#), which included a small but important update to the dependent partner requirements under the Graduate visa route. From 16 July 2025, a dependent partner will only qualify if the main applicant already holds permission under the Student or Graduate route.

Separately, the Immigration [White Paper](#) published in May 2025 proposed reducing the Graduate visa duration from 24 months to 18 months. However, this change has not yet come into effect, and the Graduate visa currently still allows a stay of up to 2 years.

Although only small policy changes have been implemented as of July 2025, the Graduate Visa route remains under review as part of broader considerations around net migration and economic growth.

Applicants and prospective graduates should be aware that further future changes to the Graduate route are possible. These could affect aspects such as eligibility requirements, permitted activities, or the overall availability of the route. Any changes would typically apply to new applicants and would not normally affect those who already hold a Graduate Visa, although transitional arrangements would be confirmed at the time.

Given the evolving nature of UK immigration policy, it is advisable to keep up to date with any announcements that may impact the Graduate Immigration Route. Seeking professional immigration advice at an early stage can help ensure that you are well-positioned to respond to any changes and to plan your immigration journey effectively.

20. Graduate Immigration Route Applicants FAQs

Who is eligible for a UK Graduate Visa?



Can I apply for a Graduate Visa from outside the UK?



What types of jobs can I do on a Graduate Visa?



How long can I stay in the UK on a Graduate Visa?



What is the cost of applying for a Graduate Visa?



Can I extend my Graduate Visa once granted?



Does time spent on a Graduate Visa count towards settlement?



What are the most common reasons for Graduate Visa refusal?



Can my dependents apply with me on the Graduate Visa?



When should I apply for the Graduate Visa?



21. How Our Immigration Barristers Can Help

The UK Graduate Immigration route offers international students the opportunity to remain in the UK for two or three years after successfully completing an eligible course. However, applying for a Graduate Visa requires careful attention to eligibility criteria, timing, and documentation. At Richmond Chambers, our specialist immigration barristers provide tailored advice and expert representation to help international graduates secure their future in the UK.

Graduate Visa Applications

If you are considering applying for a UK Graduate Visa, we can:

- Confirm your eligibility based on your course of study and visa history;
- Advise on the timing of your application in relation to course completion and Confirmation of Degree;
- Assist with gathering and preparing the required supporting documents, including the CAS reference from your sponsoring university;

- Prepare and submit a professionally presented Graduate Visa application on your behalf;
- Respond to any Home Office requests for further information or clarification.

Our approach is precise, strategic, and aimed at maximising your chances of a smooth and successful application.

Post-Visa Legal Guidance

Once your Graduate Visa has been granted, we can continue to support you with:

- Understanding the scope and limitations of your visa conditions, including work rights and restrictions;
- Exploring future immigration options if you wish to remain in the UK beyond the Graduate Visa period, such as switching to the Skilled Worker or Start-up/Innovator Founder routes;
- Planning your immigration journey in line with long-term residence or career goals.

Employer and Sponsorship Transition Support

For graduates who secure employment with a UK sponsor during or after their Graduate Visa period, we also offer:

- Advice on switching into the Skilled Worker route and the timing of such an application;
- Liaison with your prospective employer and their sponsor licence team to ensure a smooth transition;
- Representation in complex or time-sensitive switch applications where delays or refusals could impact lawful status or employment.

Whether you are a recent graduate planning your next steps, or an employer seeking to retain international talent, our immigration barristers provide expert, forward-looking guidance every step of the way.

22. Contact Richmond Chambers Immigration Barristers

At Richmond Chambers, we pride ourselves on being approachable, responsive, and proactive in understanding and meeting our clients' needs. We are a highly driven team, committed to delivering clear and reliable immigration advice as part of a professional and friendly service.

To speak with one of our immigration barristers about your Graduate Visa application, please call us on +44 (0)20 3617 9173, email us at info@richmondchambers.com or complete our online enquiry form below.

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WHAT CAN WE HELP YOU WITH?

To discuss your Graduate Visa application with one of our immigration barristers, contact our personal immigration team on 0203 617 9173 or complete our enquiry form below.

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